NOT QUITE BULLET SPEED YET

Indian Railways grapples with the dual challenge of modernising and remaining affordable while addressing issues such as overcrowding, safety and financial pressures

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One of the largest ministries of the government, Indian Railways has the dual responsibility of bringing in a much-needed technology and capacity upgrade while remaining an affordable mode of travel for the common Indian that it has always been. The first relates to India's perennial challenges: overcrowded trains, timely availability of confirmed tickets, concerns of safety. The second is a facor of the overall vision of governmental responsibility towards the people. Beyond these, the Indian rail network has to increase its share of freight moved across the country, being faster, more economical and "greener" than road transport. Railways is also under duress owing to a burgeoning pension bill of over Rs 50,000 crore per year, keeping its financial health perpetually in red. ■

▶WHAT NEEDS TO BE DONE

AUGMENT CAPACITY The focus on multi-tracking single and double lines to increase train capacity should continue. India has been successful in setting a good pace of 7.8 km per day for creating new tracks over the past decade. Key corridors such as Delhi-Mumbai and Delhi-Howrah are being upgraded for speeds up to 160 kmph. The Eastern and Western Dedicated Freight Corridors, expected to be operational this year, will reduce freight travel time by up to 40 per cent. With 94 per cent electrification achieved, the goal is to end 2024 on a high, with 100 per cent

SAFETY FIRST Despite a lot of work towards improving the record, safety continues to pose a challenge. FY24 saw a string of accidents, including collisions and derailments in Balasore (Odisha), Raghunathpur (Bihar) and Vizianagaram (Andhra Pradesh), in which more than 300 passengers were killed, due to avoidable errors. The government needs to rely on tech solutions to minimise the scope of human errors. However, while Advanced Signalling Systems like Kavach can reduce accidents by 60 per cent, layered human oversight is foundational